3.3.2 Information Withholding and Manipulation

We examine another tool populists use to undermine IOs: withholding or manipulating scientific information. This analysis replicates our results published in *World Politics* (Carnegie, Clark, and Zucker 2024). Using data from the World Bank and the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC), we demonstrate that populist governments are more likely to withhold critical scientific data or provide data of lower quality compared with that of nonpopulist governments. This dynamic arises both from a desire to avoid international scrutiny and from the domestic erosion of scientific capacity under populist regimes.

Specifically, we find that environmental and public health data, essential for the World Bank's activities, are disproportionately missing when populists are in power. As a placebo test, we analyze data not supplied by states, showing that this trend does not hold for information collected or estimated by other sources. We further show that data reported to the UNFCCC by populist governments, particularly greenhouse gas emissions figures, are of significantly lower quality compared with that of nonpopulist counterparts.

Why examine scientific data specifically? Scientific information occupies a unique position in global governance, serving as a powerful tool that legitimizes expertise and empowers technocrats (Eichengreen 2018, 7). This has made it a prime target for populists, who frequently frame their rhetoric around distrust of elites. Recent examples illustrate this tension: Populist leaders withheld or misrepresented data to the WHO regarding the origins and spread of the COVID-19 pandemic (Worsnop 2019); countries with populist governments have been hesitant to share accurate climate data with IOs;[6] and populists have failed to supply reliable development-related data to financial IOs like the IMF (Jones and Hilbers 2004).

The reluctance to provide such data stems partly from their technical nature, which requires the input of highly educated experts. For populists, whose base often harbors skepticism toward elite-driven processes, the value of producing and sharing scientific data may seem limited. In contrast, nonpopulist leaders tend to cater to constituencies that trust scientific expertise and expect high-quality data to inform decision making.